Replicating the Conservative Formula

Yingni Chang and Yikai Shen · MTH 9897 Project 8 · CRSP replication, 1929–2024

Paper: Blitz and van Vliet (2018), The Conservative Formula, Journal of Portfolio Management 44(7)

Replicate the US results on the paper's sample, 1929–2016

Then examine factor exposure, later periods and trading costs

Main recent comparison: 1990–2024; the paper ends in 2016

What we test

The rule: 1,000 largest US stocks → low-volatility half → rank on 12-1 momentum and net payout yield → best 100, equal weight, quarterly

1. Known factors: is the return explained by Carhart (primary) or FF5 + momentum (robustness)?

2. Decay: fixed periods 1929–1962, 1963–1989, 1990–2016, 2017–2024, plus rolling 120-month windows

3. Costs: net of 10 and 30 bps per dollar traded; break-even cost of the excess return and the alpha

All estimates with Newey–West (12 lags) or block-bootstrap intervals

The data

Monthly CRSP via WRDS: 1925-12 to 2024-12; extracted 2026-10-13.

Data item	Coverage / count
Security-month observations	3,954,591
Securities	26,746
Delistings	22,869 total; 2,530 imputed; 317 set to zero
Eligible universe, December 1928	393
First full 1,000-stock universe	1964-06

One share class per company; dividends implied from total minus price return.

Missing held returns: stale-price carry or in-gap price ratio; every case counted. WRDS provides no release identifier; time stamp and file hashes identify the extract.

The portfolio rule

Paper order: history screen → top 1,000 by market cap → low-volatility half → ranks among complete signals

Weights drift between rebalances; delisted holdings become cash; costs charged per dollar traded

Controls: Speculative (high-volatility half, weakest scores), standalone signals, Small, CRSP VW market

Excluded: Value (no book equity in CRSP) and Table 2 panels C–D (factors not in our sources)

deviation	our convention
Share-class selection	largest common class of each PERMCO per month (shrcd 10/11)
Size measure	security market cap for the top-1,000 cut
Dividends	implied from ret - retx (legacy retx includes non-ordinary distributions)
Missing-signal rule (NB-007)	partition first; complete cases ranked
Small early universe (DATA-001)	all history-eligible names when < 1,000 (393 at 1928-12; 500-name pool from 1964-06)
Missing monthly returns (DATA-002/010)	stale carry (0) or in-gap price ratio

Building the signals

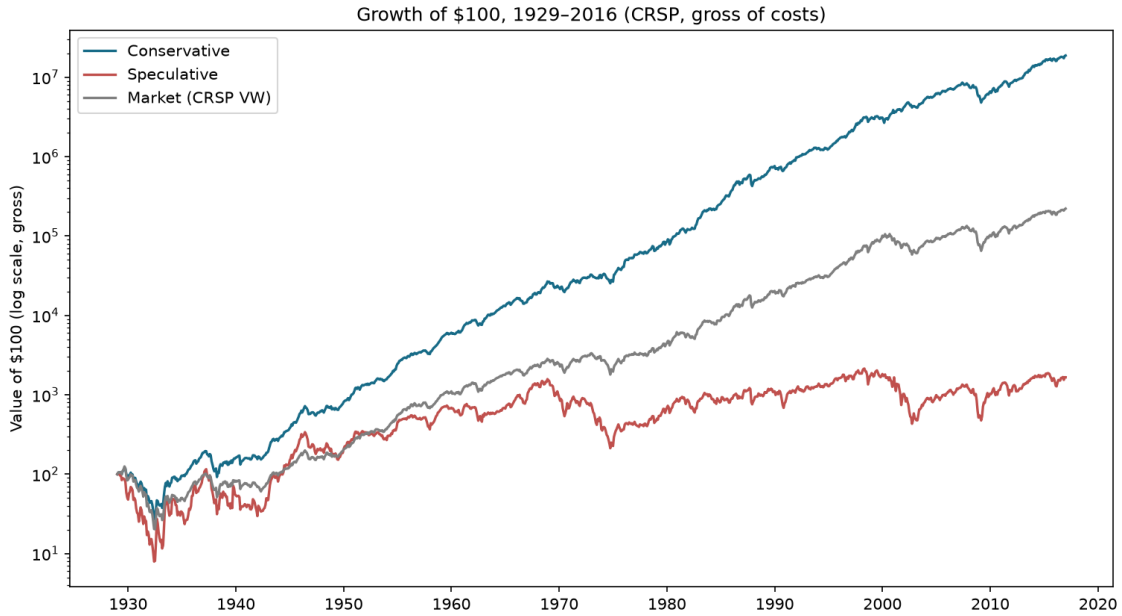
Signal	History	Calculation
Volatility	36 months	Annualized standard deviation of consecutive monthly total returns
Momentum	11 months	Compound price returns; exclude the most recent month
Dividend yield	12 months	Trailing split-adjusted dividends / current adjusted price
Net payout yield	24-month share average	Dividend yield + 1 − latest adjusted shares / average adjusted shares

A falling share count raises payout yield; new share issuance lowers it.

Quarter-end information determines next month's holdings. No forward return enters selection.

Our results versus the paper

Metric	Ours	Paper
Conservative CAGR	14.80%	15.1%
Conservative volatility	17.06%	16.5%
Market CAGR	9.15%	9.3%
Speculative CAGR	3.24%	—
Speculative volatility	35.9%	—
Quarterly turnover	38.9%	32%
Decades beating market	9 / 10	—



Gross, 1929–2016. Turnover gap unexplained; paper measure not stated. — = not shown.

paper / ours	Formula	Market	Small	Momentum	Lowvol	NPY
Return (compounded)	15.1% / 14.8%	9.3% / 9.1%	12.0% / 13.0%	15.9% / 15.5%	10.2% / 10.4%	14.5% / 14.2%
Volatility	16.5% / 17.1%	18.7% / 18.7%	31.4% / 33.5%	25.7% / 26.1%	13.3% / 14.4%	20.1% / 21.1%

Factor-adjusted returns

Annual alpha; gross unless labeled net. CMS = Conservative − Speculative; net CMS charges both legs.

Portfolio	Period	Model	Ours α	Paper α	Our t
CMS	1963–2016	CAPM	14.20%	14.0%	—
CMS	1963–2016	FF5	8.69%	8.8%	—
CMS	1963–2016	FF5 + MOM	3.12%	3.3%	—
CMS	1929–2016	CAPM	12.33%	13.9%	—
CMS	1929–2016	Carhart	7.74%	8.8%	—
Conservative	1929–2016	Carhart	3.23%	—	4.63
Conservative	1963–2016	FF5 + MOM	−0.11%	—	−0.14
CMS, net 30 bps	1929–2016	Carhart	5.78%	—	3.99

Full-sample gap remains. Adding profitability and investment reduces long-only alpha. — means the comparison or t-statistic is not shown.

How costs change the result

Annual cost estimate: quarterly turnover × 8 × cost.

1929–2016 measure	Value
Quarterly turnover: ours	38.9%
Quarterly turnover: paper	32%
Net CAGR at 30 bps	13.73%

Break-even cost (bps per dollar traded)

Period	Carhart alpha	Excess return
1929–1962	162	178
1963–1989	66	187
1990–2016	52	84
1990–2024	36	52
2017–2024	none	none

2017–2024: gross excess return and alpha already ≤ 0, so no break-even.

Early-period break-evens are high, but so were real trading costs then.

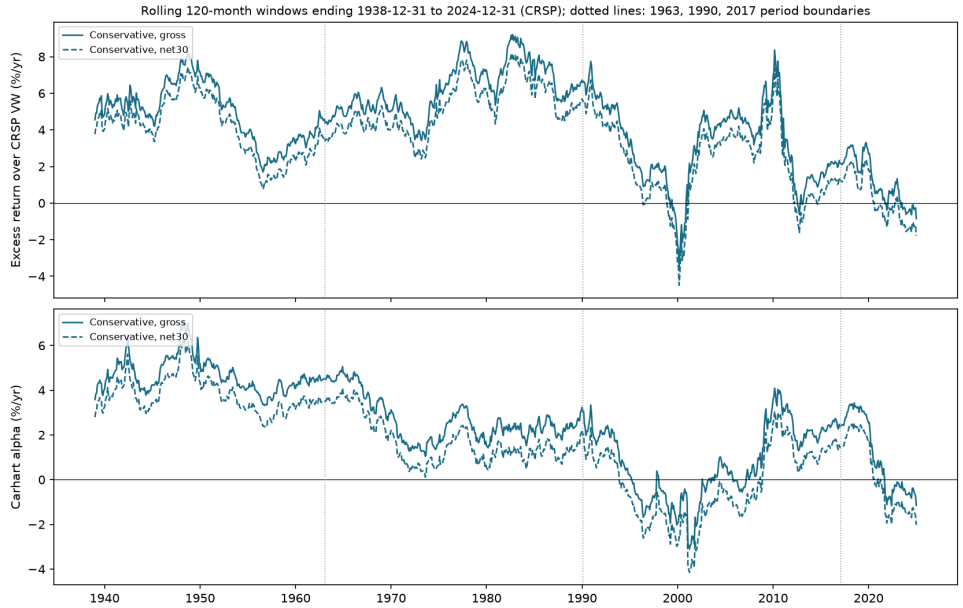
Results by period

Carhart alpha (gross): 4.7% → 2.1% → 1.7% → −1.2%

Carhart alpha is statistically significant in the two earlier periods

2017–2024 is only 96 months: interval [−5.1%, 2.7%]

period	months	excess, gross	Carhart α gross (t)	Carhart α net 30 (t)
1929–1962	408	5.2%	4.7% (5.03)	3.8% (4.14)
1963–1989	324	6.4%	2.1% (2.90)	1.2% (1.56)
1990–2016	324	2.7%	1.7% (1.34)	0.7% (0.56)
2017–2024	96	−1.7%	−1.2% (−0.61)	−2.1% (−1.06)
1990–2024	420	1.7%	1.2% (1.05)	0.2% (0.18)



The recent sample: 1990–2024

Portfolio / measure	Gross	Net 30 bps	Market
Conservative: excess over market	1.69% [−2.0%, 5.4%]	0.73% [−3.0%, 4.4%]	—
Conservative: Carhart alpha	1.17% (t 1.05)	0.20% [−2.0%, 2.4%]	—
Conservative: FF5 + MOM alpha	—	−2.00% (t −2.33)	—
Conservative: CAGR	12.2%	—	10.1%
Conservative: volatility	13.5%	—	15.2%
CMS: Carhart alpha	—	3.72% (t 2.22)	—

Brackets are 95% confidence intervals. Excess return and alpha are annualized. CMS is a separate contrast; borrow and financing costs are omitted. — means not shown.

Dividends and share repurchases

NPY = trailing dividend yield + 1 − latest adjusted shares / 24-month average adjusted shares.

Repurchases raise NPY; issuance lowers it. Splits must leave adjusted shares unchanged.

1929–2016 comparison	Annual result
Gross CAGR: net payout rule	14.80%
Gross CAGR: dividends only	13.44%
Paired net-30 arithmetic gain from NPY	1.22% [0.56%, 1.87%]

Same universe, low-volatility pool, momentum signal, weights, quarterly dates and costs.

Share changes measure net repurchases after issuance, not reported buyback cash flow.

Industry allocation and stock selection

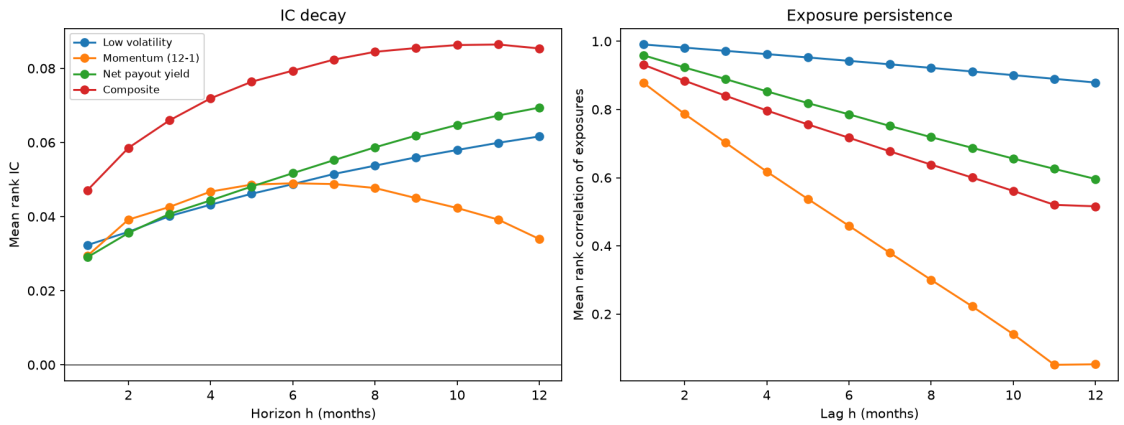
Paper scores rank across sectors (page 4). Reference: cap-weighted formation universe; quarterly constituents and industries fixed, weights drift, delistings become cash.

1929–2016 component / variant	Annual result	Return basis
Industry allocation	0.82%	Arithmetic
Stock selection	3.80%	Arithmetic
Reference-to-CRSP-market difference	0.18%	Arithmetic
Total excess over market	4.80%	Arithmetic
Industry quota: gross CAGR	14.51%	Compounded
Industry quota: net-30 CAGR	13.37%	Compounded

Quota variant: 100 slots proportional to industry security counts; apply the rule within each FF12 industry. Exploratory; changes the global low-volatility screen. Contributions are arithmetic, not causal.

Signal tests

Diagnostic	Result
Composite rank IC, 1 month	0.047 (t 8.8)
D10−D1, 1963–1989	1.02%
D10−D1, 1990–2016	0.68%
D10−D1, 2017–2024	0.40%
FMP information ratio, K = 1	0.59
FMP information ratio, K = 12	0.29
FMP IR, K = 1, 2017–2024	0.29



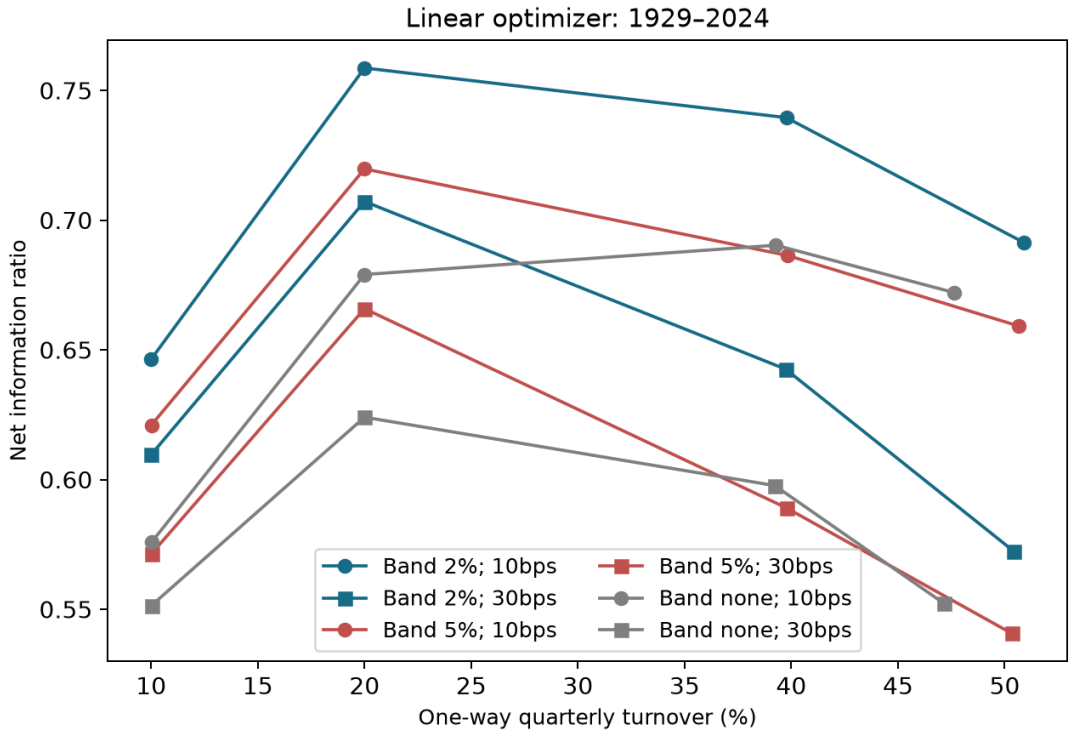
D10−D1 is a monthly decile spread. FMP portfolios are gross diagnostics and may have leverage.

Low volatility: positive rank IC, flat mean spread (right-skewed high-volatility deciles).

Long/short and linear optimization

Long/short: n = 3, 10 bps and borrow. Linear alpha: net 30 bps, annualized.

Trading / optimization measure	Result
Long/short annual excess over RF	0.64%
Long/short information ratio	0.03
Long/short max drawdown	−99.97%
2020s capacity, scaled to 2024	$7.9B
Linear alpha, 1990–2024	1.31% to 1.95%
95% intervals excluding zero	2 / 4
Linear alpha, 2017–2024	−2.71% to 0.07%
95% intervals excluding zero	0 / 12



Monthly reweighting was chosen after buy-and-hold losses (1932-08, 1933-05). Capacity assumes 10% of volume, scaled to 2024 market size; no impact model. Linear recent examples use 2–5% industry bands and 20–40% turnover budgets; intervals are unadjusted, selected from a 24-run grid. Return-scaled alpha is a later sensitivity. We also test a portfolio covariance penalty.

Mean-variance portfolios

Maximize expected return − half risk aversion × portfolio variance − trading costs

Covariance: trailing 36 monthly returns, 50% diagonal shrinkage; the window ends at formation

Return alpha: completed trailing IC × annual volatility × √(3/12) × composite exposure

Quarterly: 2% stock cap, industry bands ±5pp, two-way turnover budget 40%; scaled costs start at 30bps

Two fixed risk aversions (5 and 20); max constraint violation 4.9e-09; turnover relaxations 0

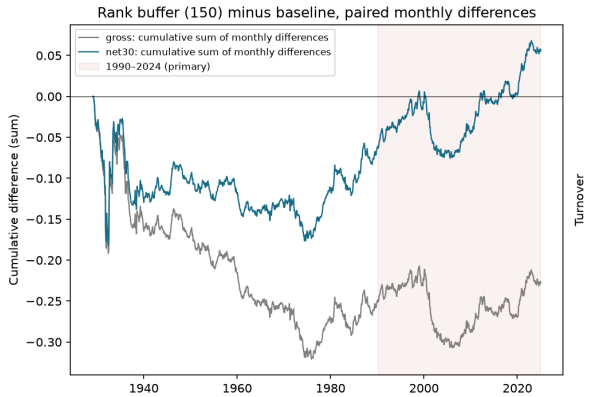
We chose these settings after examining the baseline; an unseen test is still needed

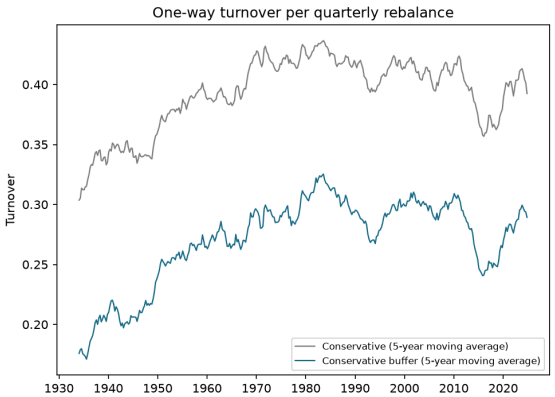
1990–2024	Net CAGR	Volatility	IR	Market corr.
γ = 5	11.59%	12.51%	0.14	0.89
γ = 20	10.39%	11.51%	−0.03	0.87

A buffer to reduce trading

Keep holdings while eligible and within the best 150 ranks.

1990–2024 comparison	Result
Baseline quarterly turnover	39.8%
Buffer quarterly turnover	28.4%
Relative turnover reduction	28.7%
Paired net-30 gain, per year	0.34% [−0.10%, 0.78%]
Paired gross gain, per year	0.06%





Net paired interval includes zero: not significant. The buffer changes holdings as well as costs.

The recent period was already seen when we tested this variant.

What we conclude

Return and volatility are close to the paper; turnover and some regression results differ

Much of the historical return is associated with known equity factors

Alphas decay; 1990–2024 net of 30 bps: alpha 0.20% [−2.0%, 2.4%]

The recent net-alpha interval includes zero

Lower volatility is the most consistent feature of the portfolio

Limitations: no CRSP release identifier; implied dividends; share-class and size conventions; turnover above the paper's; selection across grids; a short post-sample

Running the project

python -m crsp_pipeline.import_web (full web exports; licensed data kept private)

python -m crsp_pipeline build

python -m research.run_all → results/ (aggregates) + results/manifest.json

python build_notebook.py && python execute_notebook.py

python presentation/build_pdf.py (PDF slides and speaker notes)

85 result files with sha256 hashes; data manifest 4816d582000a…